



Using Unusual Indicators in Commercial Real Estate to Predict Community Trends

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Introduction

The company I worked for is a leading global real estate investment firm. The firm invests in and manages assets across key real estate sectors on behalf of its institutional clients. The goal of this project was to dig into four unusual indicators within these sectors to see what effect they had on the real estate markets in New York and Los Angeles. Specifically, we researched badging, liquor license turnover, freight technology usage, and anchor brand development to gain more insight on how these indicators impacted the market.

Purpose

To support portfolio diversification, I analyzed office, retail, industrial, and residential trends to guide strategic investment and divestment decisions.



Indicators

Sector	Indicator	What It Shows
Office	Badge Data	Real time leasing demand, work trends
Retail	Liquor License Turnover	Business vitality and neighborhood stability
Industrial	Autonomous Freight Technology (driverless trucks)	Logistics efficiency and facility demand
Residential	Anchor Stores & Lifestyle Brands	Neighborhood desirability and consumer strength

Research Question

How do unusual indicators in Office, Retail, Industrial, and Residential sectors affect Commercial Real Estate (CRE)?

Methodology

Office

I analyzed office badging data to measure employee presence and workplace utilization across key areas. This information was used to identify occupancy trends, provide real-time insight into tenant stability, and overall office market health.

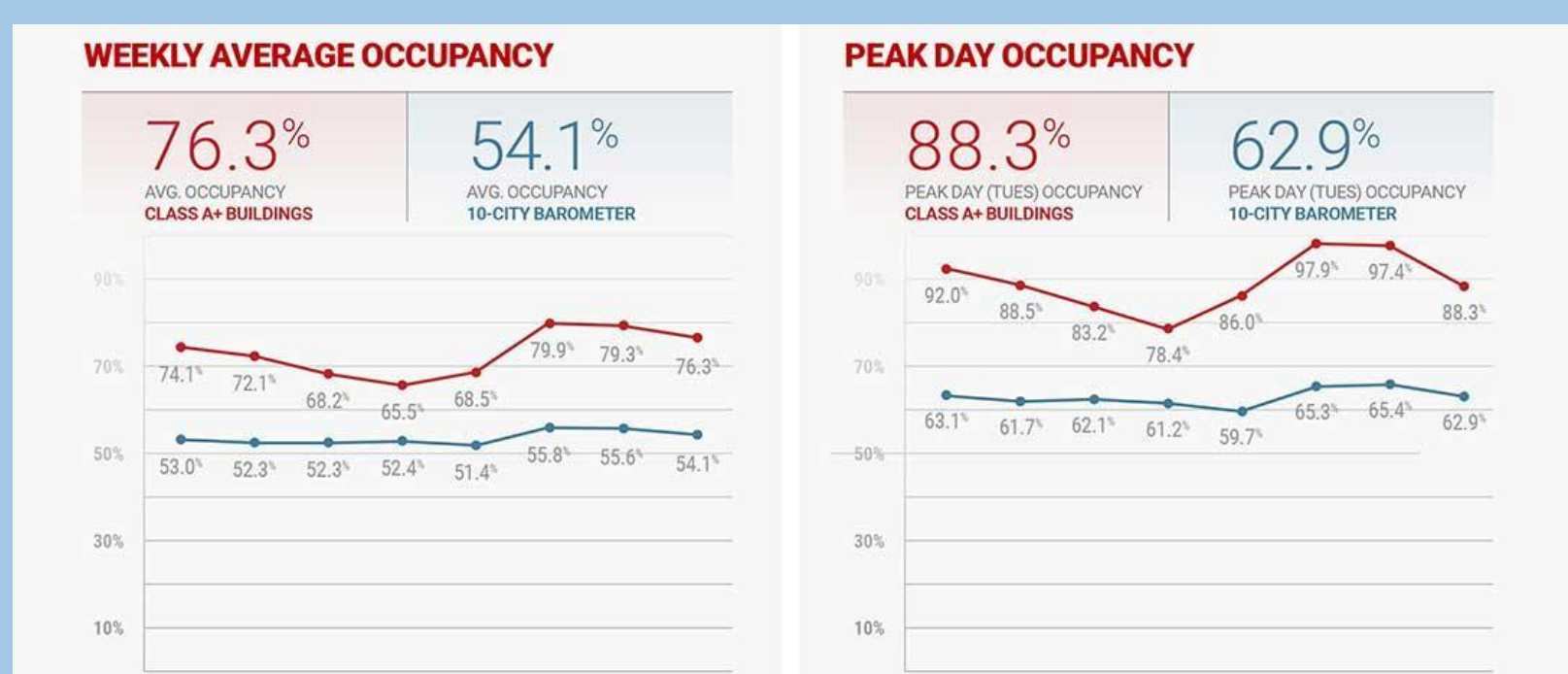


Figure 1: Average weekly occupancy from June 2025 (Kastle Systems)

Retail

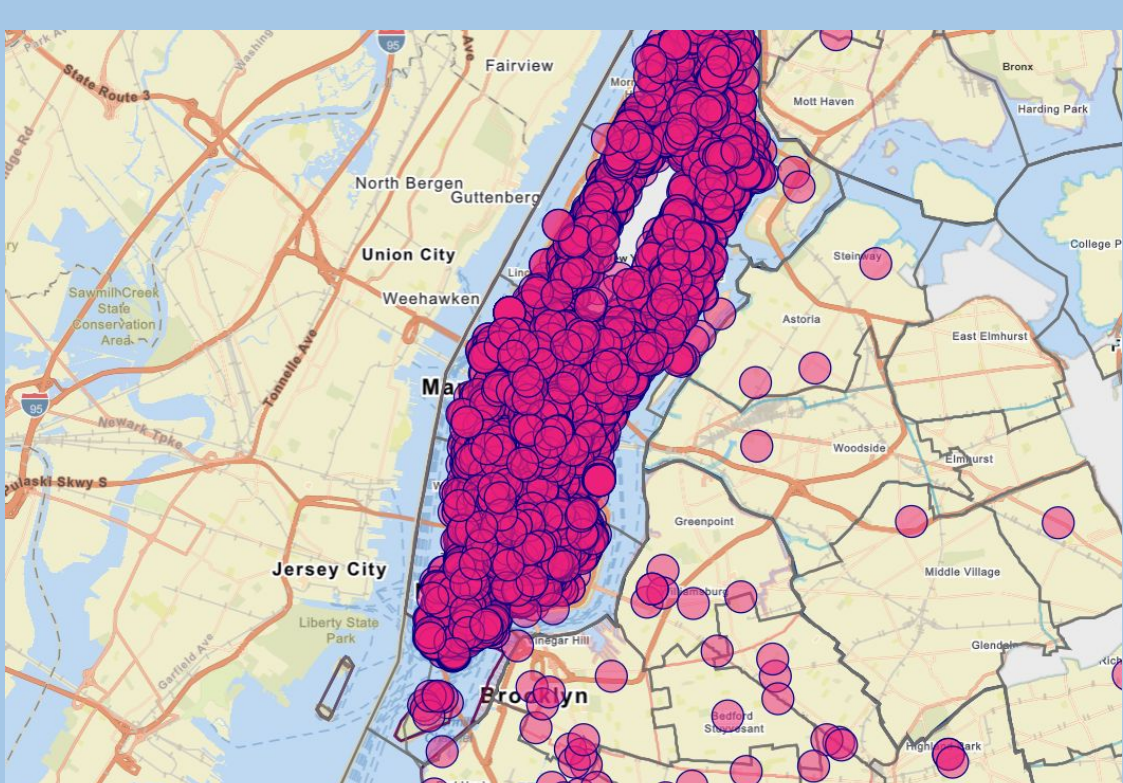


Figure 2: New York County active (8,055) liquor licenses (NYS Liquor Authority)

Liquor license turnover in an area helps gauge business vitality and is used to determine the demographics of that population. More specifically, I examined the trend in the number of active licenses vs. closed licenses in NY County.

Industrial

The rise of autonomous freight technology reflects growing efficiency in logistics operations. I tracked travel timelines and recorded mileage data as forward-looking indicators of this shift. In real estate, such advancements are expected to influence the location, design, and value of industrial facilities. As automation expands, property demand and rental rates may also increase.

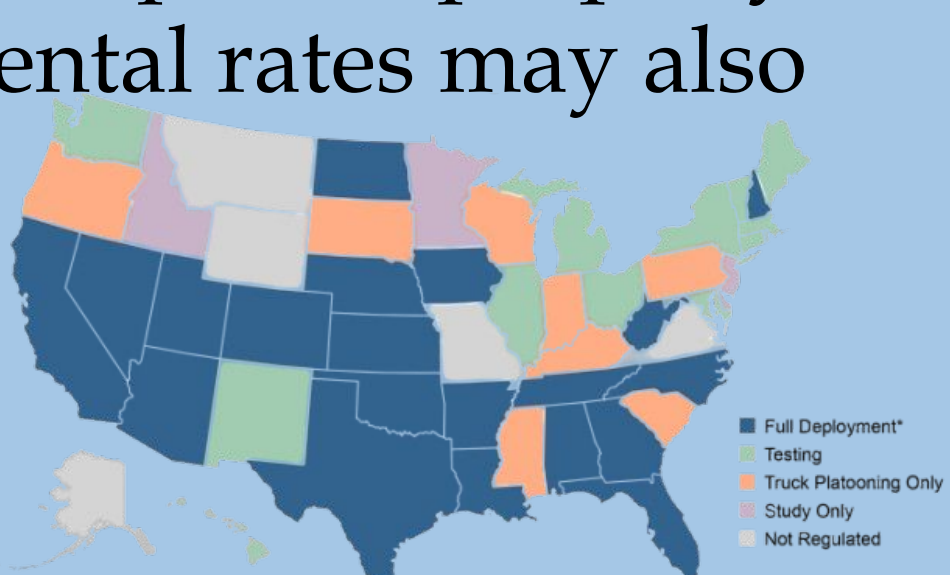


Figure 3: Autonomous Vehicle Regulation in the US (KLRD)

Residential

I analyzed the presence of retail brands and compared their locations to surrounding residential property values. The status of national brands in an area often correlates with local demographics, including age and income levels. These serve as proxies for growth, consumer demand, and overall neighborhood desirability.

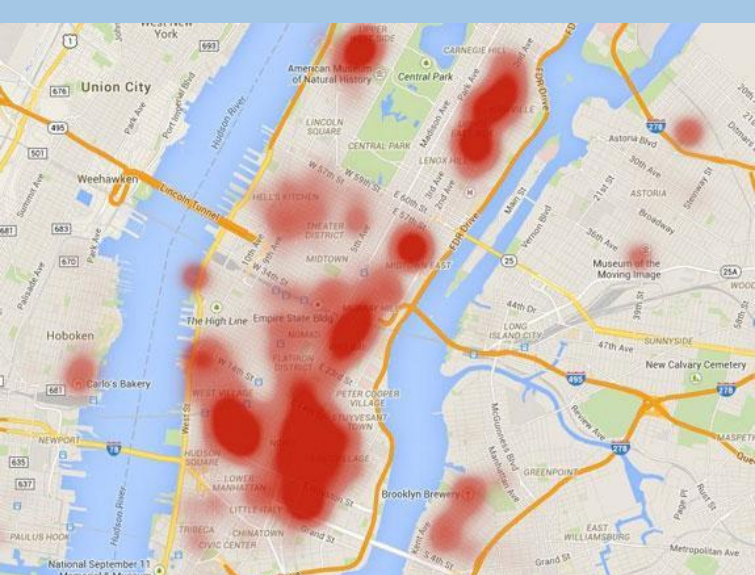


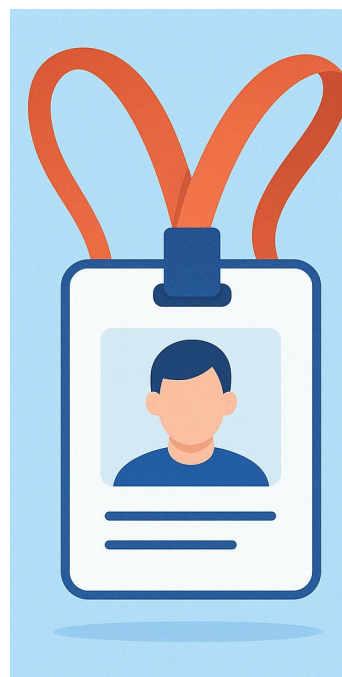
Figure 4: New York City heat map showing where a high volume of anchor stores and lifestyle brands are.

Acknowledgements

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Office

Badging data is gathered from digital IDs used by employees to enter buildings. Occupancy levels can be tracked by landlords to see usage as well as demand. Badging is becoming a non-traditional yet powerful indicator of tenant engagement. For CRE, it influences leasing strategies, property value, and investment decisions.



Retail

Frequent changes in liquor licenses often reflect instability, higher tenant risk, and weaker property performance. Conversely, steady or long-term license holders suggest sustained demand for nightlife and hospitality, providing insight into consumer spending trends.

Ex: A stable license base can indicate a neighborhood's strength or gaining popularity.



Industrial

Companies using autonomous freight technology can transport goods faster with less reliance on human drivers. This accelerates the demand for distribution centers. As a result of this adoption, properties may need larger loading and staging areas to support them. It is also possible for freight costs to drop, resulting in a higher demand for industrial real estate.



Residential



The presence of anchor stores and lifestyle brands often signal that an area has a strong or rising consumer spending power. In a neighborhood, the entry of these brands typically reflects young professionals, families, or higher income residents moving in, which can drive up demand and pricing for homes.

